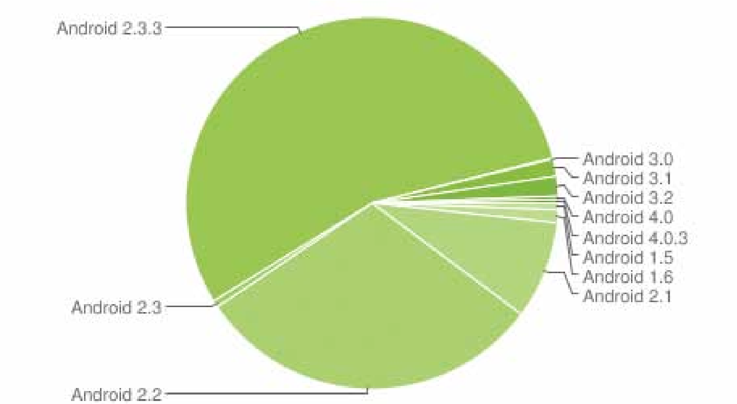

The chart shows fragmentation in Android versions as of January 2012

tions. In keeping with this spirit, Google launched the Android SDK that gave developers access to the length and breadth of Android's APIs, and programmers could access device functions such as the telephony, camera, data from the GPS device and the various sensors to create rich applications that deliver a phenomenal experience to users. This freedom spawned a range of apps such as games that would respond to changes in orientation and mapping and navigation applications that would use GPS data to pinpoint your location, and even map out the night sky for you using the phone's camera.

The Open Handset Alliance had declared that all applications within an Android system would be given equal status, as opposed to granting higher privileges to system applications like the phone or messaging. This allowed software developers to create apps that could rival the default system apps provided by the handset makers. For instance, a developer could write a third-party photo-viewing app, and a user would be given the choice of opening a photo in the default system app or the third-party one.

Google started the Android Market (rechristened the Google Play Store in 2012) to provide a one-stop venue for all app downloads. Similar to the Apple's App store for iOS devices, app developers would publish apps to the Play Store where they would be available for download. They could choose to charge a fee for downloading the apps, a portion of which would be pocketed by Google. The market gave Android a huge boost and expanded its user base, for consumers finally had a decent alternative to the iOS platform, with competent hardware, a developer-friendly OS and a rapidly growing repository of Android apps.